



Ten checks on a waterfront deck

The parts that fail first on the water, and how to find them without taking anything apart.

TEN MINUTES • NO TOOLS BUT A SCREWDRIVER

How to use this

A waterfront deck ages differently from an inland one. Salt air attacks the metal, not just the wood, so the parts that fail first are the ones holding everything together rather than the boards you are standing on. Check it before the season, not after.

- 1 Bounce on it, at the middle of a span**

Stand midway between two joists and shift your weight. A deck that moves underfoot is a deck whose framing or fasteners are going, whatever the boards look like.
- 2 Push the railing hard, at the top**

Lean into it at the corners and anywhere a run ends. Railings fail at the post connection, and a railing that gives is the single most dangerous thing on a waterfront deck.
- 3 Probe the posts at the waterline and at grade**

Push a screwdriver into the post where it meets the ground, the concrete, or the water. If it sinks in, the post is soft inside even where the outside looks sound.
- 4 Look at the fasteners, not the boards**

Rust streaks, lifted screw heads and black staining around a fastener mean the metal is failing. Salt air eats anything that is not stainless or properly rated.
- 5 Check where the deck meets the house**

The ledger connection is the most common point of total collapse. Look for separation, rot in the band joist, or bolts that have corroded.
- 6 Look under it, at the joist hangers**

Hangers rust out from the back. If you can see light between a joist and its hanger, or the hanger is scaled and flaking, it is carrying far less than it was designed to.
- 7 Check the boards around any planter or mat**

Anything that holds moisture against the deck is where rot starts. Lift them and look.

8 Walk the edges and the stairs
Edge boards and stair treads take the most water and the most weight per square foot. Soft, cupped or springing treads are a fall waiting to happen.

9 Measure the railing height and the gaps
Codes set a minimum height and a maximum gap between balusters, and older decks frequently meet neither. If a 4-inch ball passes through a gap, it is a problem.

10 Look for movement where the deck meets the seawall cap
A deck built over or onto a cap moves when the cap moves. New gaps here are often the first visible sign that the wall behind it is going.

What to do with what you find. Soft posts, a moving railing or anything wrong at the ledger are reasons to keep people off the deck until it is looked at properly. This is an owner screening sheet, not a structural inspection, and it cannot tell you what a repair involves.